

Warehouse Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

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1. Receiving & Inbound Handling

1.1 Inbound Shipment Check-In

All inbound trucks must check in at the dock scheduling gate at least 30 minutes before their assigned slot. On arrival, the dock supervisor verifies the Advance Shipping Notice (ASN) against the physical load. Any discrepancy between the ASN and the received quantity must be logged in the Warehouse Management System (WMS) within 2 hours of unloading, using discrepancy code DISC-01 (short shipment), DISC-02 (over shipment), or DISC-03 (damaged goods).

1.2 Quality Inspection

A minimum of 5% of each pallet (by unit count) must be visually inspected for damage before putaway. Pallets with more than 2% visible damage are quarantined in Zone Q and flagged for supplier claim processing. Temperature-sensitive goods (cold chain) must be scanned with an IR thermometer on arrival; anything outside the 2°C–8°C range for chilled goods must be rejected and logged as DISC-04.

1.3 Putaway

Putaway must be completed within 4 hours of dock check-in for standard goods, and within 1 hour for cold-chain or hazardous materials. Fast-moving SKUs (Category A, per ABC analysis) are stored in Zones 1–3 (closest to pick face). Slow-moving SKUs (Category C) are stored in Zones 7–9 (bulk storage, upper racking).

2. Storage & Inventory Zones

Zone	Purpose	Access Level
Zone 1–3	Fast-moving pick face (Category A)	All warehouse staff
Zone 4–6	Medium-velocity storage (Category B)	All warehouse staff
Zone 7–9	Bulk / slow-moving storage (Category C)	Forklift-certified staff only
Zone Q	Quarantine (damaged/disputed goods)	Supervisor approval required
Zone CC	Cold chain storage	Certified cold-chain staff only
Zone HZ	Hazardous materials	HazMat-certified staff only

3. Order Picking

3.1 Picking Methods

- **Single-order picking:** used for orders below 10 line items.
- **Batch picking:** used when 15+ similar orders are queued in the same time window; picker collects for multiple orders in a single pass.
- **Zone picking:** used during peak season; each picker is assigned a fixed zone and passes the tote to the next zone.

3.2 Pick Accuracy

Target pick accuracy is 99.5%. Any picker falling below 98% accuracy over a rolling 500-pick window is flagged for retraining. All picks must be confirmed via barcode scan — manual quantity entry without a scan is not permitted except during declared system outages (requires supervisor override code).

4. Packing & Dispatch

4.1 Packing Standards

Cartons must be selected based on the dimensional weight calculator built into the WMS. Void fill is mandatory for any carton with more than 20% empty volume. Fragile-flagged SKUs require double-wall cartons and a “FRAGILE” label on at least two sides.

4.2 Dispatch Cutoffs

Standard ground shipments must be handed to the carrier by 5:00 PM local time to ship same-day. Expedited/next-day shipments have a cutoff of 6:30 PM. Orders missing the cutoff are automatically re-flagged for the next dispatch wave and the customer-facing ETA is updated accordingly.

5. Returns Processing (Reverse Logistics)

5.1 Intake

Returned goods are received in the Returns Bay and matched against the original Return Merchandise Authorization (RMA) number. Items without a valid RMA are held for 5 business days pending customer contact before being logged as unauthorized returns.

5.2 Disposition

- **Resellable:** goods in original condition, unopened packaging → restocked to primary inventory after QC pass.
- **Resellable as open-box:** opened but undamaged → routed to secondary/clearance inventory pool.
- **Damaged/defective:** routed to Zone Q, then to supplier claim or write-off, per SOP-FIN-004.

6. Safety Protocols

- Forklift operators must complete recertification every 12 months.
- Any spill in a picking aisle must be cordoned off and reported within 5 minutes; cleanup crew has a 15-minute response SLA.
- Emergency exits and fire lanes must remain clear at all times — this is audited weekly by the Safety Officer.
- All staff working above 1.8 meters (rack picking) must use a certified safety harness and order picker equipment with functioning guard rails.

7. Cycle Counting

Cycle counts are performed continuously: Category A SKUs are counted weekly, Category B monthly, Category C quarterly. Any variance greater than 2% between system inventory and physical count triggers a root-cause investigation, logged under variance code VAR-01 through VAR-05 depending on cause (miscount, theft, system error, damage, misplacement).